

The Soft-Hearted Sioux

Zitkala-Sa | Answers and story summary

1. What does “soft-hearted” mean? Is the narrator soft-hearted? Explain the title’s irony.

“Soft-hearted” means compassionate and easily moved by others’ suffering. I think the narrator is soft-hearted because he avoids killing and cares deeply about his sick father. Even when he is starving himself, his father’s suffering bothers him more than his own hunger. The title is ironic because this compassionate man ends up killing both a cow and a farmer. His wish to save a life leads him to take lives, and the Christian society whose teachings he follows sentences him to death.

2. Which culture does he identify with at the beginning, middle, and end? Give evidence.

At the beginning, he identifies most closely with his Sioux family and community. He respects his warrior father’s reputation and worries that he will disappoint his family’s hopes for him (pp. 1-2). In the middle, he identifies more strongly with the Christianity taught at the mission school. He believes killing is wrong, returns with a Bible to preach, and drives away the medicine-man because he thinks his father’s soul is in danger (pp. 2-3). By the end, he is caught between both cultures. His attempt to bring his father meat reconnects him with his family’s expectation that he provide food, but he still wonders whether Jesus will forgive him or his warrior father will welcome him after death (pp. 4-5). He has not fully settled on either identity.

3. What drives him to kill the cow and the farmer? Explain his change of heart.

He kills the cow because his father is starving and he has failed to find food. Seeing his father chew on a buffalo robe makes the suffering impossible to ignore, so saving him becomes more urgent than obeying the rule against killing. He kills the farmer after the man pursues him, threatens him, grabs his shoulder, and takes the meat (pp. 4-5). The story does not describe the stabbing directly; his bloody knife and the fallen man reveal what happened. His desperation and panic overwhelm his beliefs. His compassion has not disappeared - it has driven him into violence to try to save his father.

4. Explain the conflict between the cultures and how they interpret events differently.

The conflict is between the narrator’s mission-school Christianity and his community’s expectations about faith, hunting, and family responsibility. He sees refusing to kill as compassion and believes preaching Christianity will help his people. His father sees that same refusal as a failure to provide food, while the medicine-man sees his foreign clothing and religion as signs of betrayal (pp. 2-4). The narrator sees driving away the medicine-man as protecting his father’s soul, but his father sees it as losing needed help. Finally, the white authorities punish his killing as murder, while readers also see the desperate attempt to feed his family behind it (p. 5). The story exposes the gap between Christian ideals of mercy and the punishment he receives.

5. Why is the narrator unnamed?

Leaving the narrator unnamed may make his struggle stand for the experiences of other Indigenous young people separated from their cultures through mission schooling. It also emphasizes his uncertain identity: he feels like a stranger among his own people, yet the society whose religion he adopts condemns him. His first-person voice lets us understand him through his thoughts and choices rather than through a name.

Story summary

In “The Soft-Hearted Sioux,” a young Sioux man’s family expects him to become a hunter, warrior, and provider. After nine years at a mission school, he returns as a Christian preacher who believes killing is wrong. He tries to convert his community and drives away the medicine-man who is attending his sick father. The medicine-man turns the community against him, and the people leave his family behind. During winter, his father grows weaker, and the family runs out of food. Desperate to save him, the narrator kills a white man’s cow for meat and then kills the man when he pursues and confronts him. When the narrator reaches home, his father has already died. He takes his mother to the medicine-man’s camp, turns himself in, and is sentenced to death. Awaiting execution, he wonders whether Jesus or his father will welcome him after death. The story shows the tragic conflict between the beliefs he learned at school and his responsibilities to his family.